

ALTERNATIVE PATHS TO ATTAINING STANDARD UNITS OF CREDIT

Loudoun County Public Schools (LCPS) recognizes that instruction, learning and outcomes equivalent to those achieved in 140 clock hours of instruction can be attained through alternative methods. LCPS complies with the *Regulations Establishing the Standards for Accrediting Public Schools in Virginia* (SOA), including the awarding of standard and verified credits for courses based on 140 clock hours and other criteria. In addition, the Virginia Department of Education (VDOE) permits the awarding of standard credit without 140 clock hours for work equal to the progress and learning achieved in 140 clock hours of instruction.

The intent of this policy is to offer flexibility to students in the design of their secondary course schedule, and is intended for students who have factors that impact their ability to earn the standard credit within the traditional 140 clock hours, but who seek to learn and demonstrate competency of the full content of the course's standards of learning via alternative means.

A. Competency.

1. A student has demonstrated competency by meeting the specific VDOE objectives and performance requirements of the course that match or exceed the expectations of students who have received 140 clock hours of instruction with similar standards, competencies, or objectives, including students who are receiving instruction per Policy 5360 - (Homebound and Home-Based Instruction).

2. Evidence of competency of the pertinent content and skills for a student receiving a waiver is fully documented; retained securely by the School Division, electronically or in hard copy consistent with student records retention requirements; and available for review by the VDOE, if requested.

B. Eligibility for Credit Waivers. The principal and director of school counseling may provide credit waivers to:

1. Students who enroll in school after the 20th clock hour of instruction has been completed and cannot meet 140 clock hours of instruction.

2. Students taking a course for a second time for the purpose of credit recovery.

3. Students enrolled in a course to meet their on-time graduation target.

4. Students enrolled in Virtual Loudoun courses or other virtual courses as approved by the VDOE.

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5. Students with other extenuating circumstances as verified by the principal.

C. Children of Certain Federal Employees. In order to facilitate the on-time graduation of children of federal employees serving under orders pursuant to Titles 22 or 50 of the United States Code enrolled in kindergarten through grade 12, the Superintendent or designee:

1. Waives specific courses required for graduation if similar coursework has been satisfactorily completed in a local education agency in the state from which the child is sent, brought, or caused to be sent or brought or provides reasonable justification for denial of such waiver. If a waiver is not granted to a student who would qualify to graduate in the state from which the student is sent, brought, or caused to be sent or brought, LCPS provides an alternative means of acquiring required coursework so that graduation may occur on time; and

2. Accepts, in lieu of testing requirements for graduation in Virginia, (i) exit or end-of-course exams required for graduation from the state from which the student is sent, brought, or caused to be sent or brought, (ii) national norm-referenced achievement tests, or (iii) alternative testing acceptable in Virginia.

The parent serving under orders pursuant to Titles 22 or 50 of the United States Code must present documents indicating that the parent is required to move in order to perform the parent's job responsibilities and that such move results in the student's relocation to the School Division.

D. Standard Credit. Credits achieved through the waiver option will be graded and are considered equal to any standard credit in terms of grade point average, extracurricular eligibility, and high school transcripts.

E. Appeals. This policy must be consistently and transparently implemented and communicated openly to staff, students, families, and the community.

F. Administrative Privileges. This policy shall not be construed as justification to limit the availability of 140-hour course offerings, nor shall this policy be used in a manner that limits students' ability to meet the true intent and learning requirements necessary to earn a Virginia High School Diploma. Any school or student that utilizes this policy in violation of its original intent may lose the right to offer and earn credits through this waiver. The Superintendent reserves the right to revoke this privilege for any school at any time should there be evidence that waivers are not being granted appropriately.

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1. Appeals to this policy will be considered by the appropriate secondary level director. The level director will determine the appropriateness of the application of this policy.

2. The Superintendent or designee shall resolve disputes regarding the attainment of standard units of credit via waivers in accordance with this policy. The Superintendent or designee may review whether a student was properly denied permission to seek a standard unit of credit via waiver and whether a student was properly denied a standard unit of credit after having been determined to be eligible to seek the standard unit of credit via waiver. Based on the evidence reviewed, the Superintendent or designee may (1) award the standard credit; (2) deny the standard credit; or (3) request additional documentation of competencies prior to determining whether to award the standard credit. The decision of the Superintendent or designee is final.

Adopted: 1/25/22

Current Revision: 1/30/24

Legal Refs.: Code of Virginia §§ [22.1-79.1](#), 22.1-253.13:1, [22.1-253.13:4](#), 22.1-370, 22.1-371, 22.1-380, [8 VAC 20-131-110](#)

Guidelines for Graduation Requirements; Local Alternative Paths to Standard Units of Credit, Virginia Board of Education (Oct. 2015)

Cross Ref.: Policy [5360](#), Homebound and Home-Based Instruction